and capacity of both India and the UN in shaping events on the ground. The end of Soviet influence in Afghanistan, and India's economic strains in the early 1990s severely limited New Delhi's policy options in Kabul. As an R&AW officer recollected years later, 'Dixit and gang had the guilt of not saving Najibullah. We sent the plane [in which Sevan was waiting for Najibullah, but which was not actually an Indian plane] to Kabul thinking that the Mujahideen would let him go. We told the world that we are taking Najib out, but had no understanding with Dostum. We should not have waited that long to take him out.'[27] Nambiar concurs that Najibullah could have left Kabul a little earlier, but he blames the UN, especially Sevan, for political and operational overreach:

> Let's not forget that this [exfiltrating Najibullah] is really something that has to be done under national ownership. If you think you can carry such stuff and move around, then you must have the physical capacity to do it. You must have boots on the ground. That's why even Najibullah had said, "we want boots on the ground", UN boots on the ground. Obviously they couldn't do that. It takes time to do that. The fact is, I don't think that Benon [Sevan] thought that it would come to this. He didn't expect that anybody, certainly from inside the country, would stop Najibullah from going to the airport.[28]

Dostum, many years later, told an Indian intelligence officer that had New Delhi paid adequate bribes, Najibullah might have been a free man.[29] Even if one agrees that the Indian leadership felt guilty for giving up on Najibullah, Dostum's argument that India had the capacity to bribe Dostum's men into letting Najibullah escape in those circumstances, fails to convince. Neither did India have the required capacities, nor Dostum (who had cut a deal with Massoud) the political will to let Najibullah go. 'That criminal Najibullah who we trusted, he was selling us for his own interest', Dostum had bellowed in May 1992 when Indian journalists sought clarification of his stance.[30] Najibullah had made the mistake of first creating an independent militia led by Dostum, and then trying controlling it by cutting supplies to keep the strength of his militia at a maximum of 10,000 men—both out of necessity as funds from Moscow were drying up, but also out of want, in order to keep Dostum's political ambitions in check. The plan boomeranged. Najibullah's ghost, much like his bête noir Sarwari, would haunt India. Indeed, in 1994 India dispatched senior diplomat, M. K. Bhadrakumar (who was director, 1989–91, and joint secretary, 1992–95, of the Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Iran desk at the MEA), to meet with Massoud in Kabul. Then-Indian foreign secretary Krishnan Srinivasan—an Oxford-educated diplomat